the hotel at a late hour – I can't remember exactly what time it was, but no doubt it was way past any curfew the coach might've imposed.

It being summertime in Pietermaritzburg, a very hot and humid day awaited us the following morning. And, obviously, there was a game of provincial cricket to be played. What followed that morning was one of the funniest things I have ever seen on a cricket field. Dean was our opening bowler and he was way more hung-over than the rest of us. Now Dean was also a very hairy individual, and he used to wear these neoprene cycling-shorts under his cricket longs to prevent chaffing. And he'd have on long woollen cricket socks as well.

As it was, Dean used to sweat like a miner, and on this blazingly hot and humid KwaZulu-Natal day, the sweat was running off him in rivers. He could barely hold the ball, his hands were so sweaty. He had to abort his first ball, because halfway through the run-up it slipped out of his hand.

So in he comes again – all you can hear is the swish, swish, swish of his neoprene shorts – and he delivers the ball. Except no one can tell where it's gone. There's the blur of Dean's bowling action – he was a world-class quickie, remember – but then no sign of the ball. Next thing there's this crash as a cricket ball hits the sightscreen behind our wicketkeeper, Bleekie. The ball had obviously slipped out of Dean's hand, but this time it had sailed over the batsman, over Bleekie, and bounced once before hitting the sightscreen. Vinnie, fielding at fine leg, nearly kakked himself.

I remember standing there in the covers just laughing and laughing.

Our captain, Tim Mitchell, tried his hardest not to smile and to impose some sort of order on proceedings. He had word sent to the twelfth man that under no circumstances was Dean Payne allowed any water during play or at any of the drinks breaks. So we come off the field at lunch time, and poor old Dean is just lying there on the changing-room floor with ice blocks on his eyes, basically funnelling water down his throat.

Hylton Ackerman, or 'Dutchman' as everyone called him, made playing in the B-team a fantastic experience. He was a great coach and an astute reader of the game, but also a real character. I remember one game against Free State in Bloemfontein. We were in a bit of trouble early on, but I came in and Bleekie and I started to build a good partnership, as we often did in those days. I think we posted 100 in something like 90 minutes. It was a four-day match, but Bleekie and I were flying.